TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Proposals

The proposal as persuasive planning — its types, its standard structure from problem to budget, how it differs from a report, and a model outline for a project proposal.

HUM-1107 · COMMUNICATIVE ENGLISH · TOPIC 10 · LEVEL 1 TERM 1

1. What a proposal is

A **proposal** is a document that offers a plan — to do a piece of work, supply goods, conduct research, or start a project — and seeks its reader's **approval**. Where a report (Topic 9) looks backward at facts found, a proposal looks **forward**: it describes what *should be done*, how, by whom, in what time and at what cost, and it must **persuade**, because the reader is free to say no — to choose another supplier, another plan, or nothing at all. Business runs on proposals: the exporter's offer to a buyer, the engineer's project submission to management, the researcher's application for a grant are one instrument in three settings.

2. Types of proposals

CLASSIFICATION	TYPES
By audience	**Internal** — within the organisation (an engineer proposes a new testing machine to management). **External** — to another organisation (a supplier proposes to a buyer; a consultant to a client).
By origin	**Solicited** — written in response to a request (a tender notice, a buyer's enquiry): the reader has defined the need and often the format. **Unsolicited** — offered on the writer's initiative (a firm proposes a service the buyer has not asked about): it must first create the sense of need.
By purpose	**Business/commercial** (supply, services, contracts), **project** (build, install, develop), **research** (investigate a question with a method and budget) — the student's final-year project proposal is this third type in academic dress.

3. The structure of a formal proposal

PART	FUNCTION

Title page & title	Names the proposal, the proposer and the date; the title should state the project, not merely “Proposal”.
Executive summary	The whole offer in a paragraph: the problem, the plan, the cost, the benefit — written last, read first (as in reports).
Background & statement of the problem	The situation and the need: what is wrong or missing now, with facts and figures — the section that earns the reader’s “something must be done”.
Objectives	What the project will achieve, stated measurably (reduce shade-rejection from 6% to 2% within six months).
Proposed plan / method	How the work will be done: steps, methods, materials, responsibilities — detailed enough for the reader to judge feasibility.
Schedule	The timeline: phases with dates or durations, and milestones.
Budget	Itemised cost — materials, labour, equipment, contingencies — and the terms of payment; honesty and arithmetic are persuasion here.
Qualifications	Why this proposer: experience, facilities, past work, key personnel — the credibility section, factual rather than boastful (compare Topic 8’s correctness).
Benefits & conclusion	What the reader gains, restated from the reader’s side (consideration, Topic 8), and a courteous call to approve.
Appendices	Supporting documents: drawings, specifications, certificates, detailed calculations.

4. A model outline (internal project proposal)

PROPOSAL FOR INSTALLING AN AUTOMATIC SHADE-MATCHING (SPECTROPHOTOMETER) SYSTEM IN THE DYEING LABORATORY
Submitted by: Dyeing Manager · To: Managing Director · Date: 12 November 2026

1. Problem. Shade approval now depends on visual judgement; 6% of lots are re-dyed for shade mismatch, costing about Tk 9 lakh per quarter in reprocessing.
2. Objective. To cut shade-related reprocessing below 2% within six months of installation.
3. Plan. Purchase and install one spectrophotometer with recipe-prediction software; train two laboratory staff; run parallel (visual + instrumental) approval for the first month.
4. Schedule. Procurement 6 weeks; installation and training 3 weeks; parallel running 4 weeks.
5. Budget. Instrument Tk 14.5 lakh; software and training Tk 2.1 lakh; contingency Tk 0.9 lakh —

total Tk 17.5 lakh. Payback from reprocessing savings: about 6 quarters.

6. Recommendation. Approval is requested to proceed with procurement in December.

5. Persuasive principles

- **Lead with the reader's problem, not your product** — need before solution, benefit before feature.
- **Quantify** — costs, savings and times in figures (concreteness); a proposal with vague numbers is read as a vague plan.
- **Prove feasibility** — method, schedule, budget and qualifications must each look deliverable; ambition without a plan persuades nobody.
- **Follow the reader's format** — solicited proposals (tenders) are disqualified for formal defects before their merits are read.

6. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Proposal	A document offering a plan of work and seeking the reader's approval.
Solicited / unsolicited	Written in response to a request / offered on the writer's own initiative.
Tender	A formal solicited proposal (offer) to supply goods or work at a stated price.
Executive summary	The one-paragraph condensation of the whole proposal.
Budget	The itemised statement of a proposal's costs.
Payback	The time in which a project's savings recover its cost.

7. Key points and summary

- A proposal is forward-looking and persuasive: it offers a plan and seeks approval; a report is backward-looking and factual.
- Types divide by audience (internal/external), origin (solicited/unsolicited) and purpose (business, project, research).
- Structure: problem → objectives → plan → schedule → budget → qualifications → benefits, framed by summary and appendices; persuasion = quantified need, feasible plan, reader-side benefits.

8. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. Define a proposal and state three differences from a report.
2. Classify: (a) a tender submitted for a government supply contract; (b) a salesman's uninvited offer to computerise a mill's store; (c) a student's final-year project plan submitted to the department.
3. Arrange in order and complete: Budget, Objectives, Background & Problem, Qualifications, Proposed Plan, Executive Summary, Schedule, Benefits & Conclusion — and state where the summary is written in the drafting process.
4. Rewrite this objective measurably: "To improve the quality of dyeing."
5. Draft the Problem paragraph (3–4 sentences, invented practice figures allowed and marked) for a proposal to install solar panels on a factory roof.
6. Why must a solicited proposal follow the buyer's format exactly, and what happens to those that do not?
7. Name the section that answers each reader question: "Why act at all?" / "Can these people actually do it?" / "What will it cost me?" / "What do I gain?"

Answer key

1. A proposal is a document offering a plan of work, supply or research and seeking the reader's approval. Differences: (1) direction in time — proposals look forward, reports backward; (2) purpose — proposals persuade toward a decision to begin, reports inform decisions about what has been found; (3) content — proposals centre on plans, schedules and budgets not yet spent, reports on facts and results already established.
2. (a) External, solicited, business (a tender). (b) External, unsolicited, business. (c) Internal (to the institution), solicited in effect (required by the course), research proposal.
3. Order: Executive Summary; Background & Problem; Objectives; Proposed Plan; Schedule; Budget; Qualifications; Benefits & Conclusion (appendices after). The summary stands first but is drafted last, from the finished document.
4. Example: "To reduce shade-related re-dyeing from 6% to below 2% of lots within six months, and to raise first-time shade approval to 95%." — measurable targets with a deadline.
5. Model shape: present electricity cost and its trend (practice figures), the factory's large sun-exposed roof area stated, the dependence on an unreliable/expensive supply framed as the problem, closing with the sentence that names the need the plan will meet. Marks are for facts-then-need structure and honest framing of invented figures.
6. Because evaluation compares like with like and the buyer's conditions are part of the contract being offered; formally defective tenders are rejected unopened or unscored — persuasion never gets its chance.

7. “Why act?” — Background & Problem. “Can they do it?” — Proposed Plan with Qualifications. “Cost?” — Budget (with Schedule). “What do I gain?” — Benefits & Conclusion (supported by Objectives).
